weavers still do manual *zaridosi* or intricate embroideries. Additional innovations in technology have tilted the cost and efficiency advantage firmly in the favour of the mega textile mills of Surat (Gujarat) and China. ‘Surat copies our designs, uses cheap artificial silk and often calls its products Banarasi,’ a weaver told me. This has raised poverty and job loss in Varanasi—the flip side of the ‘creative destruction’ of economic globalization.

Indian pop culture and Bollywood associate a colourful linguistic style, diction and flamboyance with the Banarasis. Many locals speak of a Banarasi identity that often trumps other group identities. And if the city is today seen as a centre of Hindu orthodoxy and Hindutva nationalism, it’s worth recalling that in the decades before the 1990s, the communist parties did very well here, winning the parliamentary seat in 1967 and coming second on four occasions (though it’s also true that in India these two things are not as opposed as they ought to be; the so-called communist parties of India also have a history of being steeped in Brahminism).[4]

Modern Hindi too arose in Varanasi. Writers led by Bharatendu Harishchandra forged it out of Khariboli—infusing more Sanskrit into it at the expense of Persian—and popularized it via theatre in the nineteenth century. Often called ‘the father of modern Hindi’, Harishchandra was a polyglot, a ‘rakish, extravagant nobleman’, and a patron of the arts.[5] His old haveli still stands in a tangled gully where his fifth-generation descendants live and warmly receive the occasional cultural tourist like me. With many old paintings on the wall, the haveli feels historic and charming, even as its younger residents chafe at its maintenance problems and dream of leaving the congested alleyways for a modern township. Avadhi and Braj are also widely spoken (Tulsidas wrote his version of the Ramayana, *Ramacharitmanas*, in Awadhi).